

CONNECTING THE DOTS

Three years of the Conviction List and booming capex plus key research

Three years of our European Conviction List. Against a volatile market backdrop, we reflected on lessons learned, which themes to watch (with a heavy dose of macro as you would expect) and made some changes to our list (below). One lesson which continues to stand out is that earnings drive stocks (for the most part). 62% of our CL names saw positive earnings revisions over the trailing 12 months, a reminder to focus on the fundamentals (earnings).

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Fresh ideas. We added **Solaria** (dislocated valuation with regulatory concerns overdone and data center optionality), **Straumann** (inflecting growth and near decade-low valuation provides a compelling entry point), **Scout24** (new products provide upside to private subscriber growth and capital returns optionality) and **IMCD** (turning point for volumes and pricing should be stickier than expected) while removing **Naturgy**, **Norsk Hydro**, and **Smith & Nephew**.

Read the [full report here](#) with the additional anniversary sections as well as refreshed write-ups for all ideas on the list as well as the new ideas below. If you prefer to listen: CL podcast [here](#).

Capex Tracker booming but narrow. Daniela Costa's proprietary tracker has seen 4.6pp revisions upwards for 2026 since the last update in May, pointing to robust demand from data centers and semis despite all the concerns around data center delays. Worth noting that the tracker concentration continues to grow; c.40% of total capex in 2026E is DC, Semis and Utils and by 2029E this is 50%+. **Daniela has a robust toolkit which is well worth following, you can listen to our 'Back to Basics' with her where we run through her toolkit, [here](#) (includes links to sign up to updates).**

GS Research from the week

We filter this week's research through the merchandising lens to highlight actionable ideas and pull out some themes / key messages which we think are important - click into the reports for more!

Conviction Lists

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European Conviction List – 3yr Edition – Lessons learned (earnings continue to drive stocks for the most part, waiting too long isn't worth it), six key themes we are watching closely and adding Solaria, Straumann, Scout24 and IMCD while removing Naturgy, Norsk Hydro and Smith & Nephew. (Jessica Binder Graham & Sahar Islam) Podcast version [here](#).

US Conviction List – Adding Amazon, Burlington Stores, Huntington Ingalls, Johnson Controls, and Occidental Petroleum, while removing Air Products and Chemicals, ConocoPhillips, Golar LNG, Loar Holdings, and Tyson Foods.

Rates

GOAL – Clearest path to equity upside from here remains rates relief / **Options on Rate-Sensitive Equities** offer an attractive hedge in a rate-relief scenario (Christian Mueller-Glissmann and Andrea Ferrario)

Fed – Push back Oct hike to Dec and strong chance additional hikes unlikely post lower core PCE (Jan Hatzius)

European Banks – Higher rates drive sustained upside to majority of consensus but be selective – preferred “rate sensitive” names are in Italy, Greece, Ireland and the Netherlands (Chris Hallam)

Credit – Last few sessions have shown weakness, y/e target risks are towards widening / more vol, EUR credit focus on French fiscal risk (Amanda Lynam)

AI / Data Centres

Entering the Agentic AI Era for the Commerce Landscape – Replay with wider team on the deep dive.

Telcos & Agentic AI – Framework, expect FCF impact to be more limited given offsetting cost savings and underlying pricing power, remain bullish (Andrew Lee)

Payments and Fintech – Investor feedback on Agentic Commerce deep dive – expect the vast majority of agentic transactions to ride on network tokenization services (Will Nance)

Micron – Strong Q and guidance, with new customer agreements and increased CapEx to support supply additions (James Schnieder)

ABB (ABBN.S) – Takeaways on new 800VDC product portfolio (Infinitus first source to rack product portf), capex for DC should go down (lower copper) but electrical equipment broadly stable, Neutral (Daniela Costa)

Dassault (DAST.PA) – CFO US roadshow feedback, AI roadmap emerging, with a rollout of plan for 3DX Agentic companions/roles and a pathway for monetisation, Neutral (Mohammed Moawalla)

Technoprobe (TPRO.MI) – Updating estimates to reflect stronger AI demand and capacity scale-up; Buy (Alexander Duval)

Previews

See all European earnings previews [here](#).

Consumer

Puig (PUIGb.MC) - CMD 28 Oct, expect more on margin upside potential and mid-single digit MT org sales, for 14x CY27 P/E cheapest name in our beauty coverage, Buy on CL (Aron Adamski)

Nestle (NESN.S) - Momentum set to improve in Q3 driven by US Pet and Europe, GSe 3.4% vs consensus +3.2% 3Q OSQ, Buy (Olivier Nicolai)

Carlsberg (CARLb.CO) - Another steady Q3 ahead despite China weakness, Buy (Olivier Nicolai)

CCH (CCH.L) - Beat incoming, GSe +9.3% org sales growth vs consensus +7.9%, Not Rated (Aron Adamski)

TMICC (MICCT.AS) - Expect momentum to continue despite tougher comps, GSe +3.5% org sales vs 3.7% consensus, Sell on low visibility on cash generation, leverage and margin expansions (Sam Darbyshire)

Beiersdorf (BEIG.DE) - Nivea to remain under pressure from competition and a subdued market backdrop, Neutral (Olivier Nicolai)

Commodities & Industrials

Trelleborg (TRELb.ST) - Pre close, thesis intact; Q3 softness looks like phasing, not deterioration, Buy on CL (Ope Otaniyi)

Total (TTEF.PA) - Capex upper limit increased and visibility extended by 2y, one of the biggest project capex increases given plans for major production growth beyond 2030 / Step ups in capex positive for CL TGS (Michele Della Vigna)

Renewables - New pockets of demand starting to emerge, Buy Nordex where TTM order intake is +60%ys 3yr ago, results 30 Oct (Ajay Patel)

ABB (ABBN.S) - Slightly decrease our FY26/27 adj. EBITA numbers (process industries weakness) but 2%/4% above VA consensus, Neutral (Daniela Costa)

OCTG - Near term risk from ME disruption but US OCTG pricing strength and deepwater should drive 27/28, Buy Vallourec (Neutral Tenaris) (Yulia Bocharnikova)

BSTL

IMCD (IMCD.AS) - Expect strength in GP/profits to continue, manufacturing PMIs mark key turning point on volumes (weak 2023-25), Buy on CL (Suhasini Varanasi)

Sika Preview (SIKA.S) - Post investor day, GSe 3Q OSG +5.1% inline with consensus with sequential pricing and positive group volumes continuing, Buy on CL (Ben Rada Martin)

IHG (IHG.L) - Raise RevPAR again, US outperform and resilient ME (partially offset by China), FY26E RevPAR c50bps ahead of consensus with upside risks, Buy on CL (Ben Andrews)

Construction - Data points to stable trends (versus consensus volume optimism), plus higher input costs mean cut numbers for Heilberg and Buzzi, more minor Holcim (geog mix and cost actions) (Ben Rada Martin)

Adecco (ADEN.S) - Moderation in organic growth (GSe 3.7% versus consensus 4.4% and 5.6% in 2Q) on tougher comps, underlying cyclical recovery fine, Buy (Suhasini Varanasi)

Maersk (MAERSKb.CO) - Separating the cyclical from the structural, likely to beat top end of guidance this year, significant upside risk to 2027 consensus, Neutral (Patrick Creuset)

Zurich (FHZN.S) - New airport near Delhi opened in June & data well below expectations, GSe EBITDA 26-28 1-5% below consensus, long-term value but overhang for now, Buy (Patrick Creuset)

Healthcare

Argenx (ARGX.BR) - Solid underlying trends; we see L/MSD% upside risk to consensus Vyvgart estimate, Buy on CL (Rajan Sharma)

Straumann (STMN.S) - Expect sustained momentum in Q3; GSe 8.5% org sales for 3Q, 30bps below consensus 8.9%, inflecting earnings and near-decade low valuation, Buy on CL (Richard Felton)

Galderma (GALD.S) - Core divisional drivers remain intact; potential for top-line guidance upgrade, Buy (Shyam Kotadia)

Lonza (LONN.S) - CMD 14 Oct, some investors cautious (-16% on 2023 CMD) but set up diff and could be positive catalyst, GSe 2030 sales/ EBITDA 6% ahead, Buy (James Quigley)

Earnings & CMDs

See all European earnings results [here](#).

Commodities & Industrials

BMW (BMWG.DE) - CMD reiterate 8-10% EBIT target and set out self-help plan, lots of AI mentions including robotics (c40% of use cases scalable), Buy (Christian Frenes)

Legrand (LEGD.PA) - CMD product portfolio announcements exceeded expectations, nearly complete product suite for DCs versus traditional white space concentration, Neutral (Daniela Costa)

Financials

SocGen (SOGN.PA) - Post CMD (implied modest consensus upgrades), versus guidance GS is slightly more constructive revenues but more cautious on costs, Neutral (Chris Hallam)

Consumer

Lindt (LISN.S) - Downgraded 2026 sales guide, cut GSe c3-4%, needs to reset price points over 18m, timing of org growth inflection uncertain, remain Sell (Sam Darbyshire)

Essity (ESSITYb.ST) - Accelerating inflation across oil derivs, GSe 11% below consensus for 3Q on 22 Oct, Sell (Aron Adamski)

Ratings Changes & Initiations

Iberdrola Up to Buy (IBE.MC) - Power infra capex to keep accelerate, expect

investment of €100bn 26-31 and double digit earnings growth (Alberto Gandolfi)

Salmon Initiations - Supply-led price increases in 2027, Buy SalMar 22% upside, c\$8bn market cap with 40%+ EPS CAGR, Mowi Neutral (Sam Darbyshire)

Zegona Initiate at Buy (ZEG.L) - Buy & 70% upside, owns & operates Vod Spain, simple single market with good growth and returns, opex/capex efficiencies drive FCF growth (Mollie Witcombe)

AJ Bell Up to Neutral (AJBA.L) - Following recent share price underperformance, with the stock's valuation now aligning more closely with the platform peer average. *See details on sector note below.* (Oliver Carruthers)

Commodities / Power

Oil - Persian Gulf exports return to 2025 level including 'dark exports', remarkable adaptation in Mideast supply and China demand suggest Brent will moderate (upside risk: energy infra attacks) (Yulia Zhestkova Grigsby) / Modeling potential **US diesel** export restrictions (Daan Struyven)

US Diesel - Who would be exposed to a ban? Largest impact will be pricing, higher in EM Asia and Europe (Megan Peters)

China Commodity Trip - Including more positive on copper price outlook - downside risk in copper supply, driven by prolonged contraction in domestic scrap supply (Trina Chen)

Cocoa - Is this the 2023-24 rally all over again? Upside price risk potential Super El Nino raises risk of poor W African crop (c65% supply) (Lina Thomas)

Sector Updates

Capital Markets - Buy CVC (FRE visibility, CL), Flatex (German pensions & new products, CL), ICG (improving cash), upgrade AJ Bell to Neutral - *see details above* (Oliver Carruthers)

Insurance - Agentic AI disruption sell-off overdone in Nordic P&C, ignores strong customer satisfaction and superior cost efficiency (Andrew Baker) / **German** pension reform - see limited impact for the insurers (Andrew Baker)

UK Homebuilders - Rallied post Help to Buy scheme (Rebecca Parker)

French Infra Tax - Q&A, full pass through could impact 7-8% of Vinci net income, 9-10% for Eiffage and more gradual for ADP but low to mid-teens (Patrick Creuset)

Tracking the data

Multi-Industry Capex Tracker - Proprietary with 4k cos, sizeable upgrades: 2026E capex 4.6pp up since May, primarily from DCs and Semis, increased concentration (Daniela Costa). Daniela has a robust toolkit - you can listen to our 'Back to Basics' with her where we run through this, [here](#).

Memory S Korea Tracker - Shows 4Q DRAM/NAND ASP forecast overall higher than GSe (Giuni Lee)

Auto1 (AG1G.DE) - Sept-26 high frequency data indicates improving inventory levels

and turns through the month with implied 3Q units sold growth at ~22% YoY, Buy (James Tate)

Reiterate Buy

Siemens Energy (ENR1n.DE) - Announced third tranche of buyback, existing run-rate implies €12bn to FY28 for buybacks (versus €6bn earmarked), expect update at CMD in Nov, Buy on CL (Ajay Patel)

Compass Group (CPG.L) - Remains a quality compounder at a discount with catalysts into FY27, minor numbers adjustments, Buy (Ben Andrews)

Halma (HLMA.L) - Photonics growth expectations dominate but broad based strength, see Photonics guidance conservative, Buy on CL (Christian Hinderaker)

Centrica (CNA.L) - Discounted valuation, inflecting earnings with options for upside, Buy (Ajay Patel)

Merlin (MRL.MC) - Assessing pipeline flexibility under new proposed Spanish DC framework and recent underperformance; reiterate Buy (Jonathan Kownator)

British Land (BLND.L) - Strong rental growth driven by lack of supply; developments and capital recycling provide further upside, Buy (Jonathan Kownator)

Management Meetings

Flatex (FTKn.DE) - CEO (former CFO –board update last week) feedback, Leadership change reflects a shift from regulatory remediation towards more commercial focus, Buy on CL (Oliver Carruthers)

Biopharma - Takeaways from our China trip, current focus on “me-too/me-better” assets and re-engineering known targets but expect more novel innovation (Asad Haider)

ASMI (ASMI.AS) - US roadshow feedback, Leading-edge Logic demand underpinned by 1.4nm adoption and tech leadership, Buy (Alexander Duval)

Smiths Group (SMIN.L) - Management takeaways, focus on acc growth, John Crane positioning for bounce back in Energy, Buy (Christian Hinderaker)

Rational (RAAG.DE) - Factory tour, China broadening, Europe is a bright spot and pricing should support margins near term, Buy (Ope Otaniyi)

Events incl M&A

Evonik (EVKn.DE) - BASF approached Evonik on potential takeover, Neutral (Marcus von Scheele). *More details [here](#).*

Flatex (FTKn.DE) - Dr Benon Janos appointed CEO with immediate effect alongside existing CEO, on CL (Oliver Carruthers)

Airbus (AIR.PA) - A321 stringer quality issue adds modest delivery phasing risk; FY26 range remains feasible (Sam Burgess)

AZN (AZN.L) - \$2bn equity investment in SSMT & clinical collab – provides optionality, Buy (Rajan Sharma)

Pearson (PSON.L) - Acquires Workera, a workforce skills verification platform (AI native), enhances ability to provide end-to-end skills ecosystem, Neutral (James Tate)

Global

US Airlines - Higher jet fuel is also the primary driver of 28% and 24% reductions to our 2027 and 2028 industry net income forecasts (Catherine O'Brien)

SpaceX - Starship Flight 14 - launch produces positive read on long-term Starship potential, several multi-trillion dollar addressable market opportunities (Eric Sheridan)

Salesforce - Thoughts on Headless post Dreamforce - headless architectures are likely to become more pervasive over the next 3 years, lean in (Gabriela Borges)

Nike - Earnings post close, FY27 guidance materially below consensus and intro Pace, new op model transformation (Brooke Roach)

Global Beer - Capital allocation & FCF opportunities replay (Leaf Liu and Olivier Nicolai)

China Spirits Tracker - Mid-Autumn Festival feedback: overall demand remained muted despite pax mobility growth; Moutai stayed relatively resilient versus other brands (Leaf Liu)

Budweiser APAC Preview - 3Q preview: continued weakness in China leading to EBITDA pressure; Korea softer volume offset by India (Leaf Liu)

Nu Holdings - Press reports potential acquisition of Monzo, which could bring additional risks (Tito Labarta)

Geely Auto Initiate - Key growth driver shifting to overseas with ample room for expansion; initiate at Buy (Tina Hou)

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Reg AC

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